

THE EARTH), 1937

Early compositions

In 1930, Britten won a scholarship to the Royal College of Music in London. While there, he produced his first compositions of note, including the choral work *A Boy Was Born*, which premiered on BBC radio in 1934. After college, he found employment writing music for the GPO Film Unit, which was then at the cutting edge of documentary filmmaking. This brought him into contact with the poet W.H. Auden, a leading left-wing intellectual, who was writing verse voice-overs for the films. In 1936, poet and composer collaborated on the celebrated documentary *Night Mail*, as well as on Britten's first song cycle, *Our Hunting Fathers*. Both men were gay at a time when homosexual acts were illegal. Auden's influence helped Britten come to terms with his sexuality. In 1937, the composer met the tenor Peter Pears, who was to be his lifelong companion. They would often give recitals together, as Britten was a first-rate piano accompanist.